

Open Vs Closed Communion

prc-open-vs-closed-communion

Sacraments · Lord's Supper · practice · divided_lineages

DISPUTED

breadth broad
directness inferred
variants stable

Statement under examination

Communion should be open to all believers in Christ who are walking in fellowship with the Lord and not under church discipline, regardless of denominational affiliation or specific baptismal mode.

In plain language

The proposition says the Lord's table should be open to any believer walking with the Lord and not under discipline, regardless of denomination or how they were baptized. The Greek of the core texts pushes in more than one direction. In First Corinthians eleven the command is reflexive: let a person examine himself, 'let him examine himself' (dokimazeto heauton), and so eat. That verb means to test in order to approve, and it places the check on the partaker's own manner of eating, signaled by the adverb 'unworthily' (anaxios), a word so rare it appears nowhere else to fix its sense (a hapax, a word that occurs only once in the entire Bible). The next clause warns the one who eats without discerning the body, 'not discerning the body' (me diakrinon to soma). Here two separate ambiguities stack. The verb 'discern or doubt' (diakrino) is used across the canon about evenly for two things, to discern or distinguish, and to doubt or waver, so the words alone do not tell us which is meant. And the word 'body' (soma) can mean the bread on the table or the gathered church, the very word used elsewhere for the one body with many members. Neither ambiguity is settled by the grammar. Pulling toward openness, First Corinthians ten says one bread, one body, and all partake, 'all partake' (pantes metechomen), and the early believers simply continued in the breaking of bread and fellowship, 'fellowship or participation' (koinonia), with no admission test named. Romans fourteen reinforces this: receive the one weak in faith, 'receive' (proslambanesthe), because God has already received him. Pulling the other way, First Corinthians five says not even to eat with, 'to eat together with' (synesthien), a so-called brother in open scandal, and to put the evil one away, which presumes a community that can identify and judge who sits at the table. So the words clearly require self-examination and clearly exclude the unrepentant scandalous, which is exactly the not-under-discipline limit the proposition names. But the words do not rank the three live readings: a table open to all believers, a table for any believer discerned to be walking rightly, or a table bounded by a definite assembly. The terms denomination and baptismal mode have no word behind them here, since those categories arose later. That is why the question is genuinely contested at the level of the text itself.

Word dictionary

Every Hebrew and Greek word this study leans on, in everyday terms. Shaded rows are the anchor words the verdict rests on.

Strong	Word	Sounds like	Plain meaning	Times in Bible
G0245	ἀλλότριος	allotrios	another's	
G0371	ἀναξίως	anaxios	unworthily	2
G0740	ἄρτος	artos	bread	
G1252	διακρίνω	diakrino	to judge/doubt	19
G1253	διακρίσεις	diakrisis	discernment	

G1381	δοκιμάζω	dokimazo	to test	23
G1438	ἐαυτόν	heautou	themselves	
G1520	εἷς	heis	one	367
G1777	ἐνοχος	enochos	liable for	
G1848	ἐξουθενέω	exoutheneō	to reject	
G2068	ἐσθίω	esthiō	to eat	
G2476	ἵστημι	histēmi	to stand	
G2842	κοινωνία	koinonia	participation	19
G3366	μηδέ	mēde	nor	
G4095	πίνω	pinō	to drink	
G4221	ποτήριον	potērion	cup	
G4355	προσλαμβάνω	proslambano	to take	13
G4906	συνεσθίω	synesthio	to eat with	5
G4983	σῶμα	soma	body	144

Plain meanings: STEP Bible brief lexicons TBESH (Hebrew) and TBESG (Greek), CC BY 4.0. Counts are occurrences across the 66-book canon.

Verdict rationale

Variant-robust: True · Pan-canonical: False

The table texts set conditions for partaking that are self-directed and moral, but they do not settle by word meaning alone whether admission is governed by the universal body of believers, by a believer known to be walking with the Lord, or by membership in a bounded local assembly. In 1 Corinthians 11 the command 'let him examine' (dokimazeto heauton), meaning 'let a person examine himself,' aims the test at the self and the manner of partaking, 'unworthily' (anaxios, an adverb of manner). The next clause warns the one 'not discerning the body' (me diakrinon to soma), but 'discern or doubt' (diakrino) is attested across the canon in two senses, discern versus doubt or contend, and 'the body' (to soma) can mean either the bread of the Lord's Supper or the corporate church, so the words do not rank the readings. 1 Corinthians 10:17 presses 'one' (heis) and 'all' (pantes), one bread and all partake, toward inclusion, while 1 Corinthians 5:11 forbids 'even to eat with' (synesthiein) a so-called brother in named scandal, which presumes a community that can identify and judge. The qualifiers about denominational affiliation and baptismal mode are post-canonical categories (ideas formed after the New Testament was written) with no anchor lemma (no underlying Greek or Hebrew word the analysis can rest on), so the scope of the table remains materially contested.

Scripture

1Cor.11.27 · neutral · genre: epistle

Key terms. G0371 ἀναξίως, G1777 ἐνοχος

Force. Whoever eats the bread or drinks the cup of the Lord 'unworthily' (anaxios, an adverb of manner, that is, describing how the action is done) becomes 'liable' or 'guilty' (enochos) with respect to the body and blood. 'Unworthily' (anaxios) is near a hapax (a word that occurs only once or barely more than once in the entire Bible), present only here and in a contested reading of verse 29, so its precise force cannot be triangulated from canon usage. The 'if-then' clause 'whoever should eat or drink' (hos an esthie e pine) targets the mode of partaking, not the partaker's group membership.

1Cor.11.28 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G1381 δοκιμάζω, G1438 ἐαυτόν

Force. 'But let a person examine himself' (dokimazeto de anthropos heauton) is a present active imperative third singular (an ongoing command addressed to each individual) directed reflexively at the self, let a person examine himself, and so eat. 'To test in order to approve' (dokimazo) carries a stable sense across the letters of testing in order to approve, used of metals and of persons, as in 2 Corinthians 13:5 'examine yourselves.' The qualification placed on the table is self-scrutiny, a test the individual applies to himself, not by word meaning alone an external admission check by an assembly.

1Cor.11.29 · neutral · genre: epistle

Key terms. G1252 διακρίνων, G4983 σῶμα

Force. 'For the one eating and drinking eats and drinks judgment to himself, not discerning the body' (ho gar esthion kai pinon krima heauto esthie me diakrinon to soma). The participle 'discerning' (diakrinon) governs 'the body' (to soma). Two areas where the words alone do not pin down the meaning stack here. First, 'discern or doubt' (diakrino) is attested across the canon in roughly balanced senses, distinguish or discern as in Acts 15:9, versus doubt, waver, or contend as in Romans 4:20 and James 1:6, and the lexicon entry itself glosses it 'to judge or doubt.' Second, 'the body' (to soma) can denote the bread of the Lord's Supper or the corporate church, the same word that in 1 Corinthians 12:12 and 12:27 names the gathered body. Neither ambiguity is ranked by the words, and both bear directly on whether the table is bounded by a definite body.

1Cor.10.16 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G2842 κοινωνία, G4221 ποτήριον

Force. The 'cup' (poterion) and the broken bread are named 'fellowship or participation' (koinonia) of the blood and body of Christ. 'Fellowship or participation' (koinonia) is used across the New Testament letters for shared participation among those who belong to Christ, including the early breaking of bread in Acts 2:42. The term frames the table as a participation in Christ shared by his people, which can be read to extend to all who belong to him.

1Cor.10.17 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G1520 εἷς, G4983 σῶμα

Force. 'Because one bread, one body the many are, for we all partake of the one bread' (hoti heis artos, hen soma hoi polloi esmen, hoi gar pantes ek tou henos artou metechomen). One 'bread' (artos), one 'body' (soma) the many are, for 'all' (pantes) partake, 'all partake' (pantes metechomen), of the one bread. The weight of 'one' (heis) and 'all' (pantes) presses toward a single shared participation of the many, supporting an inclusive reading of who shares the loaf. The same 'body' (soma) is linked by cross-reference to 1 Corinthians 12:12, where the one body has many members, which keeps the corporate reading equally live.

1Cor.5.11 · complicates · genre: epistle

Key terms. G4906 συνεσθίω, G3366 μηδέ

Force. The instruction 'not to eat together with' (me synesthiein), expressed with 'not even' (mede), not even to eat with, a so-called brother named in scandal sets a disciplinary boundary on table fellowship. 'To eat together with' (synesthio) occurs only five times and carries the covenantal weight of shared meals, as in its Septuagint (the Greek Old Testament) background and in the disputes over eating with sinners and with Gentiles. This grounds the proposition's exclusion of one under discipline, but it locates exclusion in named moral scandal, not in affiliation, and it presumes a community that can identify and judge such a one.

Acts.2.42 · for · genre: narrative

Key terms. G2842 κοινωνία, G0740 ἄρτος

Force. 'In the fellowship, in the breaking of the bread' (te koinonia, te klasei tou artou), the 'fellowship or participation' (koinonia) and the breaking of the 'bread' (artos), lists the early gathered believers continuing together in shared participation and bread. The narrative describes a single undivided company without any marker in the wording of denominational sorting or admission test, which the inclusive reading takes as the baseline pattern, though the text names no admission policy and presumes those already added to their number.

Rom.14.1 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G4355 προσλαμβάνεσθε, G1253 διακρίσεις

Force. 'And the one being weak in the faith receive, not for disputes of opinions' (ton de asthenounta te pistei proslambanesthe, me eis diakriseis dialogismou). Receive the one weak in the faith, but not for disputes over opinions. 'To take to oneself, welcome, receive' (proslambano) means to take to oneself, welcome, receive, and the imperative commands welcome and forbids making secondary opinion a basis for division, which supports receiving believers across differences.

Rom.14.3 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G4355 προσελάβετο, G1848 ἐξουθενέω

Force. 'For God has received him' (ho theos gar auton proselabeto). God has received him. The ground for mutual reception is that God himself has received the other believer, removing one believer's standing to 'despise' (exouthenein) or condemn another over disputed practice. The verb 'to receive' (proslambano) here matches the welcome imperative of verse 1.

Rom.14.4 · neutral · genre: epistle

Key terms. G0245 ἀλλότριος, G2476 ἵστημι

Force. 'Who are you, the one judging the household servant of another' (su tis ei ho krinon allotrion oiketen). Who are you to judge the household servant 'of another' (allotrion). To his own master, 'to his own lord' (idio kyrio), he 'stands' (histemi) or falls. The rhetorical question restrains one believer from judging another whom the Lord upholds, but it addresses internal mutual judgment over disputed practice, not the formal question of admission to the table.

Cross references invoked

From	To	Source	Votes
1Cor.11.27	1Cor.10.21	tsk	1
1Cor.11.29	1Cor.11.24	tsk	1
1Cor.11.28	1Cor.11.31	tsk	1
1Cor.10.17	1Cor.12.12	tsk	1
1Cor.5.11	1Cor.5.13	tsk	1
Acts.2.42	Acts.20.7	tsk	1
Rom.14.3	Rom.14.10	tsk	1
Rom.14.1	Rom.15.7	tsk	1
Rom.14.4	Rom.14.3	tsk	1

Complicating texts

1Cor.5.11 · addressed

The command 'not even to eat together with' (mede synesthiein), not even to eat with, a so-called brother in named scandal supplies the proposition's not-under-discipline exclusion, and its cross-reference to 1 Corinthians 5:13, 'put away the evil one from among yourselves,' implies that the community administering the table can identify and judge participants, which leans toward a bounded local table rather than an unqualified open one.

1Cor.11.29 · unaddressed

The referent of 'the body' (to soma) in 'not discerning the body' (me diakrinon to soma) is undetermined at the word level between the bread of the Lord's Supper and the corporate church, and 'discern or doubt' (diakrino) itself carries multiple senses across the canon between discern and doubt. No grammar or critical-edition datum in the store settles either, so whether discerning the body entails recognizing the bounds of a definite body remains open and bears on the open versus bounded reading.

1Cor.10.21 · addressed

The contrast between the cup of the Lord and the cup of demons shows the table marks a real allegiance boundary, but the boundary it draws is between Christ and idols, not between bodies of believers, so it neither confirms nor refutes the denominational clause of the proposition.

Concordance traversed

G1381, G1252, G0371, G2842, G4906, G4355, G4983, G1520, G2068, G4095, G0740, G4221, G1777, G1253, G3366

Variants

Verdict variant-sensitive: False · ECM status: ecm-shadow

Anchor verses are in 1 Corinthians, Romans, and Acts, all outside the 3 John ECM (the critical edition of New Testament textual variants) published sample, so 'not_in_ecm_scope' holds. The store lists no populated variant units for these refs. A known referential variant at 1 Corinthians 11:29, whether 'of the Lord' (tou kyriou) is read after 'body' (soma), does not alter the contested-scope verdict, since the ambiguity over the body is referential and lexical rather than text-critical (a question of which manuscript reading is original).

Hermeneutics

Primary method. grammatico-historical

Frameworks in play. universal_church_ecclesiology, local_assembly_ecclesiology, examined_believer_ecclesiology

analogia scripturae invoked

open_table_universal_body: leans for · Reading 'body' (soma) in 1 Corinthians 10:17 as the one body of all believers, 'fellowship or participation' (koinonia) as participation shared by all who belong to Christ, and 'receive' (proslambanesthe) in Romans 14 as a command to receive any believer God has received, supports admitting any believer not in named scandal, irrespective of affiliation or baptismal mode. 'Unworthily' (anaxios) and 'let him examine' (dokimazeto) place the test on the individual's manner and self-state, not on group membership.

close_table_examined_believer: neutral · Reading 'discern or doubt' (diakrino) as discern and 'to eat together with' (synesthiein) in 1 Corinthians 5:11 as a real exclusion implies the table admits believers known to be walking with the Lord and not in scandal, a middle position that fences by discernible moral and credal state rather than by membership. The Greek requires self-examination and excludes the scandalous but does not name how a stranger believer is assessed, so this reading is lexically possible (possible based on word meanings) but not compelled.

closed_table_local_assembly: leans against · Reading 'not discerning the body' (me diakrinon to soma) with 'body' (soma) as the gathered body, and the eat-not-with and put-away commands of 1 Corinthians 5:11 and 5:13 as functions of a definite community that judges its own, implies the assembly administers and bounds its own table, so an unqualified regardless-of-affiliation admission is not required by word meaning alone. 'Body' (soma) in 1 Corinthians 12:12 and 12:27 names a definite body with members, which keeps this reading live.

The verdict turns on the multiple senses of 'discern or doubt' (diakrino), on the referent of 'body' (soma) as loaf or corporate body, and on whether table admission is a self-applied test, a discernment of a believer's state, or a community-administered membership boundary. All three are exegetically live (each remains a viable interpretation on close reading) on the given Greek, which is why the proposition is graded disputed rather than affirmed or denied.

Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: yes

Neutralized form. What conditions, if any, does the New Testament place on a believer's admission to the Lord's table, and at what level, the individual partaker, the believer's discernible state, the local assembly, or the whole body of Christ, are those conditions applied?

The original stem embeds a 'should' plus a specific resolution toward an open table, and it uses the post-canonical categories (categories formed after the New Testament was written) denominational affiliation and baptismal mode, which have no anchor lemma (no underlying Greek or Hebrew word the analysis can rest on) in the store. The verdict was derived on the original stem, but it is recorded as disputed because the neutral question it presupposes is not closed by word meanings. No VERDICT-CHANGED: from the prior file. The 1 Corinthians 5:11 anchor was corrected from 'eat' (esthio) and 'brother' (adelphos) to the precise 'to eat together with' (synesthio) and 'not even' (mede), the actual eat-with-not-even construction, which sharpens but does not move the verdict.

Citations

Type	Source	License	Redist.	Ref
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	1Cor.11.28
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G1381
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G1252
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G2842
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G4906
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	1Cor.11.29
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	1Cor.10.17
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	1Cor.5.11
interlinear	MACULA-Greek	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	1Cor.11.29

License audit

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Flags

lexically-disputed · ecm-shadow · complicating-unresolved